

The only opinion that matters

If you're in the business of selling soap, toothpaste, beverages, clothes, etc., the game very rarely changes. Sure, tastes will, fashion will, and you need to stay ahead of the curve, but the game is always the same, the players are usually known, and you can see trends develop rather easily.

Take the famed Coke and Pepsi wars, for instance – bitter battles have been fought in advertising campaigns, and huge amounts of money have been spent, but the real game always seemed to favour the first mover, or the one with more pull in distribution channels. Majority market share has changed hands between the two in some countries, but it's been rare enough to allow both companies to make money.

Back in the late 90s and early 2000s, it was impossible to imagine that companies such as Yahoo!, Nokia and Microsoft would ever face any serious competition. There are other names you can add to that list – Ericsson, Motorola, RIM, etc. No one expected any other company to be able to beat any of these at their own game. And of course, no one ever did.

The problem with technology is that it's the game itself that changes. Sometimes so subtly, that people don't notice it until it's too late.

When the race to get personal computers into people's homes took off, people experimented with hardware that had specific software loaded. Want new software? Buy new hardware! It doesn't take a genius to understand why that trend was quickly reversed. For decades after that, it was the software that sold the hardware. The love for games sold GPUs, and it continues to do so. However, as hard as GPU manufacturers want to try and change that, the...err... game remains the same.

Take BlackBerry for instance. With its BES and BIS services, it was able to corner the enterprise market for phones and email on the go. Somewhere along the way the general public discovered BBM, and was hooked. Why pay for SMS when BBM is "free". That word is in quotes because obviously, you pay a little extra for a BlackBerry connection – not to mention a slight premium for the handsets as well. However, the game's changed again. Facebook and Twitter are the new way to get in touch with people, privately or publicly, and pretty much every smart-phone (and some dumb ones) can connect to

these services for you. Research in Motion has a tough task ahead of itself, because it needs to play the new games – the app game and the cross-platform game, for starters.

Even internet giant Google hasn't been without its failures – Orkut, Wave and Google+ just didn't catch the public's fancy the way Facebook, Twitter and YouTube did. It bought YouTube, of course, but still seems to be a little behind on the social game.

It's not like Facebook isn't fighting either – as we covered in a cover story previously, it has its own set of challenges ahead of it.

The technology game has all boiled down to one thing really – listen to your customers. You're the ones buying the products, and you're the ones who don't really have anything to gain or lose, and are passionate about the products you purchase. Yours is the only opinion that matters.

Every year we conduct a reader survey, and ask you to point out our flaws, and let us know what you'd like to see less or more of in the magazine. This year we've been lucky enough to also get some partners on board to provide a few lucky people with exciting prizes for taking a little time off to help improve this magazine we all love. If you turn the page you'll find details of the Digit Reader Survey 2012 (www.thinkdigit.com/drs). Please ensure that you take a little time out to give us your feedback, we would really love to serve you better.

Although Digit has been the largest selling Indian technology publication for over a decade, we also know that it's only you that keeps us at that position. In fact, one of the requirements of working here at Digit is humility – we're all just readers who applied on a whim, and then stuck on because we loved our jobs, the magazine and technology in general.

We're looking for a fresh batch of people to train and release into the technology world, so if you're feeling as whimsical as we once were, send your CV to me, and you could be a part of this crazy ride through the technology world called Digit.



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"...it was the software that sold the hardware. The love for games sold GPUs, and it continues to do so"

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

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